

of that, they assume all the *awesome* maintenance expenses that come with being a homeowner.

Alex and Shelby might have been saving money for years, but you can bet your bottom dollar they aren't saving much now. The mere concept of investing their money anywhere else (like in retirement accounts, stocks, or real estate) went right out the window when they closed on their house. The only "wealth" that Alex and Shelby have is the slowly building equity in their home.

As a result of this choice, Alex and Shelby are stuck. They can't change careers, and they can't change location. If an opportunity with a huge pay raise in another city comes up for Shelby, she can't take it—at least not in the near future. She has "invested" far too much in her new home to up and move. Because they are already taking the highest-paying jobs they can find in their local city, Alex and Shelby are unlikely to receive massive raises in the next few years.

Alex and Shelby are now "house poor." They spend everything they earn on their living expenses, massive monthly mortgage payment, and unexpected home maintenance costs. They must work their current high-paying jobs indefinitely, fighting to climb the corporate ladder. It'll take years, if not decades, of promotions and raises to finally return to a cash-flow-positive lifestyle, and only then do they have a shot at starting to save money again.

They're in a weak position if they want to start a business. They're in a tough spot if one parent wants to quit their job to raise their children. They can't do anything more than take a few low-cost vacations per year—they certainly can't take six months off and travel the world like they always dreamed of doing.

Alex and Shelby will slowly slip into the middle-class trap. They will passively accept the next phase of their careers to move up the corporate ladder one rung at a time. They will forget their dreams of being leaders in the community or spending significant time with their children during the formative years of their lives. They will basically live paycheck to paycheck, even if they build "home equity" on paper by paying down their mortgage and eventually benefiting from appreciation.

This struggle will continue for decades, but it will get better someday. Maybe ten or twenty years down the road, Alex and Shelby will reassess